THE GOLDEN FIELDS

A HOST OF UNLIKELY INDIAN SPORTS HEROES ANNOUNCE THEIR ARRIVAL AT THE RECENT COMMONWEALTH GAMES

By Suhani Singh



AVINASH SABLE, 27

Steeplechase (3,000m), SILVER

Photographs by GETTY IMAGES

At the 22nd edition of the Commonwealth Games, pretty much all the 2020 Olympic medallists from India (barring Lovlina Borgohain) returned with a medal. But the Birmingham Games was not so much about India's expected dominance in wrestling or its impressive showing in weightlifting or the superhuman credentials of table tennis player Sharath Kamal Achanta who, at 40, won three golds and one silver (essentially a medal in all the events he competed in). It was most memorable as a competition where sports enthusiasts found new athletes to root for and follow. There was the female quartet of Lovely, Pinki, Nayanmoni and Rupa Rani, who with their surprising victory had a nation googling what lawn balls was all about. Olympic champion Neeraj Chopra was missing but the athletics contingent still made a strong showing, winning medals in some unexpected disciplines—high jump (Tejaswin Shankar), 3,000 metre steeplechase (Avinash Sable), triple jump (Eldhose Paul) and 10 km walk (Priyanka Goswami and Sandeep Kumar). Two young weightlifters, Jeremy Lalrinnunga and Achinta Sheuli, overcame injuries to win their respective weight categories.

Some used experience to improve their personal bests. Backstroke specialist Srihari Natraj was one such candidate, making it to two finals against a strong field including Australia, England and South Africa. The CWG may not have the toughest competition, but it did provide a window to gauge India's medal prospects for the Asian Games and the Paris Olympics in 2024. Going by the showing in Birmingham, there is enough reason for optimism. ■

TEJASWIN SHANKAR, 23

High jump, BRONZE

A Higher Power

Three days before the Games began, Tejaswin Shankar wasn't even sure he'd make it to Birmingham. Shankar had taken the Athletics Federation of India to court for non-selection despite meeting the eligibility mark. With the Delhi High Court ruling in his favour at the nth hour, he anxiously awaited the UK visa. "Once I got here, I knew what I had to do," says Shankar, who leapt 2.22 metres to clinch India's first ever medal in the discipline.

Shankar, the son of a lawyer couple in Delhi, initially